

MY FIRST LOVE

Page 1.

She had dark auburn hair which hung down to the middle of her back in big, splendiferous curls. She was beautiful. I was speechless and weak in her presence. When she smiled at me I actually felt like my chest was going to burst wide open.

Her name was Sydney Hopper.

She was six years old and I was her slave.

I mean if that little girl had've asked me to throw myself down in front of the street car, I would've asked her "which one?"

We were both in the first grade at George Washington Grade School. Some way I had ended up at the desk behind her a few weeks after we had started school. Most classes were seated alphabetically but our teacher, after the first few weeks, had moved us around according to our apparent learning abilities.

I don't remember the system but I was put in with the bunch that already knew how to count some and knew their A.B.C's. I could even read a little, thanks to the time I spent spread out on the floor with the funny papers.

All that didn't mean a hoot to me though. All I know is I sat behind Sydney and to me that was better than being President of the United States or having a free ice cream cone.

Before school started I would always look for her so I could walk into the building engulfed in the aura that I imagined to be permanently around her.

Offering to carry her book satchel would have been more than I was physically or psychologically able to handle.

Our teacher, Mrs. Stilwell must have realized I was smitten by Sydney. How could you hide something like that? Anyway she would sometimes pair off the kids to do different things and she would always put Sydney and I together. Next to Sydney I loved Mrs. Stilwell the most.

The high point of any school day was when Sydney and I would go down the stairs and out the back steps of the school to pound the chalk dust out of the erasers. Mrs. Stilwell would take all the erasers off of the rail at the bottom of the blackboard and stack them in a cardboard box which she would then hand to me. I accepted this token of great trust from her just as though it were a box full of gold bullion, and Sydney and I would go out into the big wooden floored hallway and down the stairs. I can still remember today the smell of the school hallways. They had a strong cedar odor which came from the sawdust soaked in cedar oil that the

janitors used to sweep down the halls.

We would clomp down the big wooden stairs to the main floor and then go out the back door to a special place where all eraser cleaning was supposed to be done. This place was a large air well which surrounded some windows that opened off of the boiler room in the basement. There was a galvanized pipe railing around the three sides of this air well and the rail was slick and shiny from all the hands that had run across it over the years and also from all the pounding of chalk dust that took place on the rails.

That was the place where all eraser cleaning was supposed to take place. It was forbidden to pound the erasers on the face of the brick walls of the building - or the concrete steps or sidewalks just on the pipe railings - no place else.

Oh, yeah?

Some brave souls would pound the erasers on the building anyway and then they'd blame it on another class. If there happened to be kids from two different classes cleaning erasers at the same time, you would often

see the boys pounding the eraser on one another. Sometimes the girls would gently pat themselves on the face as they had seen their mothers applying face powder.

All of this kind of foolishness just helped to take the boredom out of something that a lot of kids considered a real chore. And some teachers used eraser cleaning as punishment.

"All right Chickie Brown and Robert Hale, just for that, you two will remain after school and clean the erasers!"

So there!

Our teacher was a real diplomat. She could make the worse things into fun. She made eraser cleaning an honor reserved to a select few rather than a punishing chore. That was why I liked to do it so much. It meant two things when I got to clean the erasers. First it meant I was something special in Mrs. Stilwell's eyes, and secondly it meant I would get to be in the intimate presence of HER. Sydney.

When we were engaged in our cleaning task I would bang away at that railing sometimes with an eraser in each hand, pounding, pounding, making that pipe literally ring to the blows which were being placed upon it by my eager hands.

Chalk dust would fly and depending on the wind would swirl around us, like desert sands in a windstorm.

Sydney would squeal,
"Stop it. Stop it. You're getting chalk dust all over me!"

At this point I would apologise and tell her I was sorry and why didn't she go back up and just sit on the steps and let me finish the job. This was one of my earliest lessons in being manipulated by a female.

I always wanted to someday take those erasers and bang out a message on the red brick walls. Printed boldly in eraser applied chalk dust, would be my confession.

"I LOVE SYDNEY"

I never gained the courage to do it though.

Some time during the summer, between first and second grade, Sydney moved away with her family. Her father was transferred to Tulsa by his company and I never saw her again.

In later years when I was grown up and had a beautiful wife and three children I was playing with one of my daughters who was about six years old. She had told me about being selected to clean the erasers at her school, and

I thought about Sydney Hopper and Mrs. Stilwell and George Washington Grade School. I told my daughter about how I used to clean erasers too, when I was a boy. I asked her to go get the eraser off of the blackboard we kept in our kitchen for messages and family reminders.

She brought the eraser to me and we went out onto our concrete driveway. I began pounding out letters in chalk dust on the surface of the concrete. At last I had done it. I spelled it out.

I LOVED SYDNEY.

My daughter asked,

"Daddy, who is Sydney?"

"Just a girl I used to know, honey....
a long time ago."